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Exam Hack of the Day

"If I Were" — Not "If I Was"

The Rule:

If your sentence begins with "if" and describes something
hypothetical / imaginary / unreal — always use "were", never "was".

Why? This is called the subjunctive mood. It signals that something is not real.
It applies to ALL subjects — I, he, she, it — always "were", never "was".

WRONG

- x If I was a bird, I'd fly away.
- x If he was taller, he'd play basketball.
- x If she was the president...
- x If it was up to me...

CORRECT

- ✓ If I were a bird, I'd fly away.
- ✓ If he were taller, he'd play basketball.
- ✓ If she were the president...
- ✓ If it were up to me...

But wait — "was" is fine when it's a REAL possibility:

✓ "If I was rude to you yesterday, I apologise."
(This might have actually happened — it's real, not hypothetical.)

vs. "If I were you, I'd apologise."
(You can never actually be someone else — hypothetical.)

Where this comes up in exams:

Narrative / creative writing — "If I were stranded on an island..."
Argumentative writing — "If the government were to ban..."
Formal letters — "If I were in your position, I would suggest..."

Quick test: Is the situation impossible or imaginary?
Yes = were **No** = was

**NOTE: This is one of the most common grammar mistakes in O-Level scripts.
Getting it right instantly signals strong grammar to the examiner.**

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